Stephane Hatgis-Kessell
Stanford, California — stephhk@stanford.edu— American and Greek Citzen

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Computer Science
September 2024 — Present
Advisor: Emma Brunskill
GPA: 3.94/4.3
Stanford University

B.S., Computer Science with Turing Scholars Honors
Year of completion: 2024
GPA: 3.8/4.0
University of Texas at Austin

Awards, Grants, and Recognition

National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship
Awarded $\approx \$150,000$
2024 - 2029

Best Computer Science Honors Thesis Award
Selected as the top undergraduate computer science thesis among 32 undergraduates defending an honors thesis.
2024

UT Austin Dean's Honored Graduate in the College of Natural Sciences
Given to 1% of graduating students who exemplify and embody the highest ideals of the college.
2024

Honorable Mention of the 2024 CRA Outstanding Undergraduate Researcher Award
2024

University-Wide Award for Top Research Project, UT Co-Op George H. Mitchell Award
One of two undergraduate students awarded $\$7,000$ at a university with more than 40,000 students.
2023

Pre-Prints

Alexander Wan, **Stephane Hatgis-Kessell**, Tomás Aguirre, Percy Liang, Rishi Bommasani, *Economic Evaluations of Language Models*, https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.19375

Stephane Hatgis-Kessell, Tomás Aguirre, Alexander Wan, Rishi Bommasani, *Estimating Time Spent on Work Tasks*, `https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.05172`

Stephane Hatgis-Kessell, Logan Bhamidipaty, Emma Brunskill, *Repairing Reward Functions with Human Feedback to Mitigate Reward Hacking*, https://arxiv.org/abs/2510.13036

Conference and Journal Publications

TMLR '26
Stephane Hatgis-Kessell, W. Bradley Knox, Serena Booth, Peter Stone, and Scott Niekum, *Influencing Humans to Conform to Preference Models for RLHF*, https://arxiv.org/abs/2501.06416.

AAAI '24
W. Bradley Knox*, **Stephane Hatgis-Kessell***, Sigurdur Orn Adalgeirsson, Serena Booth, Anca Dragan, Peter Stone, and Scott Niekum, *Learning Optimal Advantage from Preferences and Mistaking it for Reward*, arxiv.org/abs/2310.02456, AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence.

TMLR '23
W. Bradley Knox*, **Stephane Hatgis-Kessell***, Serena Booth, Scott Niekum, Peter Stone, and Alessandro Allievi, *Models of Human Preference for Learning Reward Functions*, arxiv.org/abs/2206.02231, Transactions on Machine Learning Research.

RLDM '22
W. Bradley Knox*, **Stephane Hatgis-Kessell***, Serena Booth, Scott Niekum, Peter Stone, and Alessandro Allievi, *Extended Abstract: Partial Return Poorly Explains Human Preferences,*, Multidisciplinary Conference on Reinforcement Learning and Decision Making. Selected for oral presentation.

* denotes equal contribution

Workshop Publications

RLC '26
Stephane Hatgis-Kessell, Emma Brunskill, *When are LLMs Sufficient Policy Optimizers for Sequential RL Tasks?*, The AutoRL Workshop at the Reinforcement Learning Conference. Selected for oral presentation.

RLC '26
Stephane Hatgis-Kessell, W. Bradley Knox, Emma Brunskill, *Specifying Reward Functions for RL Without Environment Sampling*, Third Reinforcement Learning Beyond Rewards Workshop at the Reinforcement Learning Conference.

ICML '23
W. Bradley Knox, **Stephane Hatgis-Kessell**, Sigurdur Orn Adalgeirsson, Serena Booth, Anca Dragan, Peter Stone, and Scott Niekum, *Learning Optimal Advantage from Preferences and Mistaking it for Reward*, 2023 ICML Workshop on The Many Facets of Preference-based Learning (MFPL). Selected for oral presentation.

Professional Service and Leadership

Member, Stanford HAI AI Policy Working Group
Selected member contributing to interdisciplinary research and initiatives on AI governance and policy.
10/25 - Present

Reviewer, ICLR (2025, 2026), ICML (2026)

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, Stanford
ECON 295/CS 323: The AI Awakening: Implications for the Economy and Society
3/29 - 6/9

Teaching Assistant, UT Austin
CS 128H: Honors Introduction to Computer Science Research
1/22 - 5/22

Employment

Robotics Institute Summer Scholar, Carnegie Mellon University Robotics Institute
Worked in the Advanced Agent Laboratory on emergent communication in multi-agent reinforcement learning, collaborating with Prof. Katia Sycara.
6/22 - 9/22

Research Intern, Bosch R&D, Reinforcement Learning for Autonomous Driving Group
Worked on preference-based reinforcement learning, collaborating with Dr. Alessandro Allievi, Prof. Brad Knox, Prof. Peter Stone, and Prof. Scott Niekum.
3/21 - 6/22